

Q I want to wear my usual clothes for as long as possible. When will I need to start wearing maternity clothes?

It is usually around the start of the second trimester that women find their waistbands start to tighten. From this point onward, wearing your usual clothes becomes increasingly difficult and uncomfortable.

You may find early on in pregnancy that your bust size has gone up a little and your tops are fitting more snugly, but you can still wear your existing clothes. By 20 to 24 weeks, though, and perhaps earlier, your clothing choices may become restricted and you may feel that you need to start wearing real maternity wear. Invest in a few key pieces that make you feel and look good. Many women don't worry about trying to disguise their pregnancy and prefer to wear form-fitting clothes to flatter their new shape.

Hardworking staples Loose tunics and empire-waist tops that you already own may fit comfortably until well into your second trimester.

Extending the life of your clothes

A stretchy belly band is a great pregnancy innovation. Made in soft, breathable materials, the wide band is worn over your belly and the waistband of your clothes to cover any gaps that appear between your top and bottom garments. The effect is a seamless look of smart layering. The band's snug elastic fit helps to hold your pants up, too, so you can leave your zipper or buttons undone. After the birth, it can handily cover up post-delivery flab and reduce the amount of flesh you reveal if breast-feeding.

Other options

- » Expand the waistband of your pants and jeans: thread an elastic hair band or sturdy rubber band through your pants button hole and loop each end around the pants button.
- » Long tops will keep your emerging belly covered during your first trimester, since they won't ride up too much with your growing belly.
- » Empire-waist tops, loose-fitting tops and tunics, and wrap-around tops and dresses are ideal during the transitional period when most of your clothes are too tight, but you're not big enough for maternity wear.
- » Long t-shirt dresses and jersey skirts can stretch to accommodate your belly during the transitional period.
- » Borrowing your partner's clothes can come in handy at the beginning of your second trimester. Check if any shirts or tops will work as casual wear for weekends and evenings.



Q Which fabrics will be most comfortable in pregnancy?

You may feel hotter than usual in pregnancy due to your increased blood circulation, so opt for lighter, breathable fabrics. It is a good idea to wear light layers that you can remove or add to easily to feel just the right temperature. Natural fabrics such as wool, silk, linen, and cotton are ideal, and there are organic versions of these fabrics if you want to avoid unwanted

chemical exposure and prefer their softness. Newer fabrics such as bamboo and hemp are also soft and breathable. All these fabrics are hypoallergenic and will feel very comfortable against your skin. Many women experience itchiness as their skin stretches to accommodate the baby, so avoid synthetic fabrics such as polyester, viscose, and nylon, which may irritate your skin. Look out, too, for stretchy natural-fiber clothes containing lycra, such as cotton leggings, since they will be most comfortable to wear as your belly grows.

You may find that as your belly grows, you **prefer** to wear clothes that are designed to **flatter your new, curvier figure** and show off your belly rather than hide it.